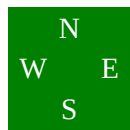


Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 9 8
♥ Q 5 2
♦ 9 7 5 4
♣ Q T 6

♠ K 6 5 4 2
♥ A K 8 7 4
♦ A
♣ K 3



♠ Q J T 7 3
♥ J 3
♦ 8 6 2
♣ J 9 5

♠ -
♥ T 9 6
♦ K Q J T 3
♣ A 8 7 4 2

West	North	East	South
	1♠	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by North

if they don't split 3-2 you will have two trump losers. So you assume that they are split just like you need them to be.

At trick two you duck a trump. That's right, you lose a trump trick early. Since you have to lose a trump sometime, you do it at a time when the defenders can't hurt you. So a defender wins the trump trick, but now a ♠ play won't hurt because dummy still has a trump to ruff with! In fact, whatever they play next you will win, pull the outstanding trumps, then run dummy's ♦ suit.

This is a very rare play, but a good one to remember.

When you have a trump loser but still need to pull their trumps, it may be better for you to lose an early trump trick rather than a later one.

South's 6♥ response to Blackwood showed one Ace and a ♠ void. North is to play 6♥. East leads the ♠Q.

Losing: ♠ = ?? ♥ = 1 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 1 ??

Of course you ruff the ♠ in dummy. East wouldn't underlead an Ace at a slam contract, and since you have a certain trump loser you cannot afford to lose a trick to West's ♠A.

Dummy has some great ♦s, but you can't expect to run them unless you have pulled all the trumps. But if you play ♥A K 4 the defenders will take their trump trick and immediately set the contract with the ♠A. There **IS** a way around the problem.

First off, you must get a 3-2 split in trumps because

Board 2

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J T 9 8 3

♥ 6

♦ K J 9 7 4

♣ J T

♠ A K Q

♥ A K 9 8

♦ A T 8 6 3

♣ 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 6 5

♥ 5 4 3 2

♦ Q 2

♣ K Q 9 7 3

♠ 7 4 2

♥ Q J T 7

♦ 5

♣ A 8 6 4 2

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♦

Pass

1♥

Pass

4NT

Pass

5♦

Pass

6♥

All Pass

6♥ by South

Agreed that the bidding wasn't much. The final contract is still a good one. South is to play 6♥. West leads the ♠J.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 4

There really aren't 4 ♣ losers since they can be ruffed in dummy. In fact you should see that this is an ideal cross-ruff hand, ruffing ♣s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. Since neither hand can be over-ruffed you expect to make all 8 trumps.

Remember, when playing a cross ruff, you need to take any side suit winners first, otherwise a defender may be able to discard that suit while you are ruffing. So you win the ♠A, then take the ♠K, then . . . what?

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Well, if you win the ♠Q, then the two Minor suit Aces, you'd be set up to cross-ruff the hand out for all 13 tricks. But here's what might happen if you try.

East might ruff the ♠Q. OK, no disaster yet. But he might then play a trump. Your slam is now kaput. You can no longer make 8 trump tricks and will end up down 1.

The answer is to not be greedy for that overtrick. With West's opening ♠ lead there is an indication of possible length there. So, realizing that East could be short in the suit, take just the 2 ♠ tricks that you need for the slam, then play your Minor Aces and start the cross-ruff.

When playing a cross-ruff you must take all the side-suit winners you need early so they won't get ruffed later.

Don't jeopardize your contract trying to take too many.